

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

ChristmasTide 1
28 December 2025



Bethlehem Star @2018
Virginia Wieringa, viriniawieringa.com

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Coventry Carol

Break Forth, O Beauteous Heavenly Light (ERMUNTRE DICH)

In The Bleak Midwinter (CRANHAM)

Still, Still, Still

God Rest You Merry, Gentlemen

Love Came Down At Christmas (GARTAN)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome & Words of Gathering

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

On this day of joyful celebration,
we join the praises of the Angels
and of all creation in heaven and on earth.

Because of God's dream, all things are created;
today God's love shines in the face of Jesus;
today God's gracious Spirit is on the move in our world.

*God of life, receive our gifts of love and joy;
unite our hearts in your peace and hope,
and make us co-creators in your work to renew the earth
as we gather in the name of the One who was promised.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Christmas

***Hymn of Christmas**

Joy to the World

Joy to the world! The Christ is here!
The gift of peace to bring!
Let ev'ry heart a welcome place prepare.
And heav'n and nature sing,
And heav'n and nature sing,
And heav'n, and heav'n and nature sing!

Joy to the earth! The Savior lives!
With song your voice employ;
While fields and floods, rock, plains and hills
Repeat the sounding joy,
Repeat the sounding joy,
Repeat, repeat the sounding joy!

Christ fills the world with truth and grace,
And asks each life to prove
The glories of God's righteousness
And wonders of God's love,
And wonders of God's love,
And wonders, and wonders of God's love!

GPHaddon

Please be seated

Lighting of the Candles

Sarah Fuhrmeister

Over the past four Sundays we have lit our Advent candles.
We light them again and remember...
the ways hope, peace, joy, and love
are always brought to birth in, through, and among, all creation.

On Christmas Eve, we shared these truths
when we lit candles together.
It was a time for memories and remembering...
a time to wonder and to give thanks.

Today, we also light our Christmas candle:
the Christ candle.
It brings light and love as we celebrate today.

This is a candle of understanding
which drives away fear.
This is a candle of truth.
And its light will lead us in unknown paths
to learn more about the mysteries of life.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.

A Christmastide Prayer

Rev. Fregin

Holy One,
on this Christmastide morning,
our hearts are filled with praise.

Even in the midst of this chaotic time
we remember -
our lives are filled with blessing,
our dreams are filled with hope,

and our world is filled with promise,
if we make it so.

May we know these precious paths
of our lives,
and may we nurture the
future they promise.

*As those who know and love
this uncommon joy,
we pray this in the name of
the One who has been born again.
Amen and Amen.*

The Lord's Prayer

Sarah Fuhrmeister

And together we pray as Jesus taught us...

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

Please stand in body or in spirit ~

*** A Christmas Tide Carol**

The First Nowell

The first Nowell the angel did say
was to certain poor shepherds in fields as they lay,
in fields where they lay keeping their sheep,
on a cold winter's night that was so deep.

Refrain
Nowell, Noël, Noël, Noël,
Jesus is born, let us sing Noël.

They looked up and saw a star
shining in the east beyond them far;
and to the earth it gave great light,
and so it continued both day and night.
Refrain

This star drew nigh to the northwest;
o'er Bethlehem it took its rest,
and there it did both stop and stay,
right over the place where Jesus lay.
Refrain

*** Passing of the Peace**

LVF

The birth of Jesus was announced
by the Angel's song of Peace and Goodwill.
The life of Jesus was a covenant of Peace and Love.

In this Season of Christmastide,
we give thanks to God
for this never-ending gift of Peace,
illusive as it may be.

This morning, may the hope, peace, joy, and love of our God be with you all.
And also with you!

Please be seated

Musical Gift

"The People That Walked In Darkness" from *Messiah*
Scott Graff, *Soloist*

G.F. HANDEL

A Reading From the Gospel

Sarah Fuhrmeister

The Story of the Shepherds and the Angels Luke 2:8-20

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Musical Gift

"Angels We Have Heard On High"
Brandon Harris, Christin Byrdsong, Sarah Fuhrmeister, and Scott Graff

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

In our more cynical or despairing moments,
we wrestle with faith
and with the idea of you coming to us, O God;
But, somewhere in our hearts we know,
that we do not need you to come,
because you have always been here
with us,
among us,
within us.

And so now, as we welcome you again,
we acknowledge you need no welcome;
it is we who need to remember
who need to see again your presence,
who need to allow your 'with-us-ness'
to flood our hearts and lives.

*Welcome to our world, Jesus
but more importantly, we thank you
for welcoming us
into your ever-coming, always-present world.
Amen and Amen!*

Musical Gift

“He Shall Feed His Flock” from *Messiah*
Brandon Harris and Christin Byrdsong, *Soloists*

G.F. HANDEL

Sharing of the Eucharist & Homily

Rev. and Dr. Fregin

Communion Liturgy

This is the moment.
This is the day of gladness,
the rebirthing of love!
And we listen for the sounds of joy.

Here, among angels and shepherds,
and among our ordinary lives,
and our everyday places,
grace emerges.
And we watch for the signs of the Holy.

In this time,
in every time,
we hold our breath in awe
for the wonder of the Christ.
*For this and so much more,
we give thanks!*

Christmastide Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Let us embrace the wonder of this last week of the year
with expectation and reimagination...

Let our hearts be secure in this dual reality:
we are worthy recipients of love and support
we can never earn,
and we are worthy providers of love and support
others cannot earn.

*Let our hearts be secure,
for hearts know and understand
and will respond if invited in.*

[J.A. Hobart]

Wherever your path takes you,
may these days of Christmastide
be for you and yours,
days of celebration,
days of hope,

days of peace,
luminous days.
*May Christ our Light
go with us in this,
and every season,
of our lives.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

***Christmas Hymn of Response** *Good Christian Friends, Rejoice*

Good Christian friends, rejoice, with heart and soul and voice!
Listen now to what we say: News! News! Jesus Christ is born today.
Ox and ass before them bow and they are in the manger now.
Christ is born today! Christ is born today!

Good Christian friends, rejoice, with heart and soul and voice!
Now you hear of endless bliss: Joy! Joy! Jesus Christ is born for this!
They have opened heaven's door, and we are blest forever more.
Christ was born for this! Christ was born for this!

Good Christian friends, rejoice, with heart and soul and voice!
Now you need not fear the grave: Peace! Peace! Jesus Christ was born for this!
Calls you one and calls you all, to reach the everlasting door.
Christ was born for this! Christ was born for this!

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-In-Residence
RESONET IN LAUDIBUS (Donald M. Corbett)